



Not All is Right in Left

KOLKATA The Left Front partners in West Bengal are a frustrated lot today. While the protests following Nandigram have gradually become louder, the allies haven't been able to stomach the lack of communication and consultation by big brother CPI(M).

A month ago, after the November 11 incident, a senior RSP leader and PWD Minister Kshiti Goswami had expressed a desire to resign from the Cabinet but he was stopped by his

party. Now, in one of the most significant moves in the Left Front's 30-year history in the state, another of its allies, the Forward Bloc (FB), has decided to contest the forthcoming panchayat elections on its own.

The polls, scheduled in May next year, will see the FB fielding its own candidates wherever it perceives its position as strong. After a state council meeting, FB's state Secretary Ashok Ghosh confirmed that they were

SOLO: Ghosh says Forward Bloc will contest alone

assessing their district-wise strength. The party will stay with the state Government and the Front as a whole and will also seek the help of its Front partners to constitute district boards and panchayat committees after the polls.

While Ghosh says there is no question of breaking away from the Left Front or joining hands with the Opposition parties, it is clear that FB is miffed how CPI(M)—which won the 2006 assembly elections single-handedly—has begun ignoring its partners.

The FB's move means that wherever the party fields its candidates, the Left votes will be divided. It also gives the party more bargaining power. Also, the Front unity is an emotional issue with senior Left leaders, as they believe they have created history by staying united for so many years.

For CPI(M), already reeling under post-Nandigram criticism, it is a situation they should go far to avoid. **by Swagata Sen**

SIGNPOSTS

ISSUED: By the Election Commission, a notice to Congress President **Sonia Gandhi** on her "merchants of death" remarks in relation to Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi.

DIED: M. Shanmugavel, 81, former editor of Tamil



evening paper **Makkal Kural** and English daily **Trinity Mirror**. He was

also the chairman of the Makkal Kural Group of companies.

WON: By the **Indian women's weightlifting team**, the Commonwealth Powerlifting championship in Christchurch, New Zealand. They bagged 11 gold, five silver and three bronze medals.

ISSUED: To former cricketer **Mansur Ali Khan Pataudi** and his family, notices by the state administration for alleged unauthorised occupation of land worth crores in five villages in Madhya Pradesh.

VIS-A-VIS **BUDDHADEB BHATTACHARYA** West Bengal chief minister **versus** **PRAVIN TOGADIA** VHP general secretary

“What's the historical evidence of Ram's birth? The birth of Ram and that of the Ramayana were the imagination of a poet.”



SAURABH SINGH



“If Ram is imaginary, then Lord Buddha, after whom the chief minister is named, also did not exist. So he should change his name.”

EPILOGUE: Politicians also seem to be blessed with vivid imagination these days.